Topic 1 — Stone Age (Prehistoric India)

Covers syllabus (click to expand)

Origin of Human Beings | Stone Age | Paleolithic Age | Mesolithic Age | Neolithic Age | Chalcolithic Culture | Important Paleolithic Sites | Important Mesolithic Sites | Important Neolithic Sites | Important Chalcolithic Sites | Cave Paintings | Rock Shelters | Bhimbetka Rock Shelters | Microliths | Neolithic Revolution | Burzahom | Mehrgarh | Chirand | Koldihwa | Mahagara

Sources baked in: NCERT Class 11 *An Introduction to Indian Art* (Ch 1), *Themes in Indian History Part I*, RS Sharma, ASI, Ghatnachakra Stone Age (B–10+), UPPCS Prelims PYQs 2018–2025, UKPCS / sister papers **Weight:** ★★★ — site↔state matching, period↔tool, archaeologist names, UP neolithic sites **Last verified:** September 2026 **Current Affairs:** N/A (purely historical; no scheme/ministry/appointment surface)

1.1 Origin of Human Beings

Modern *Homo sapiens* | Africa first | South Asia ~65,000–45,000 BP

- Modern *Homo sapiens* evolved in **Africa** about **300,000–200,000 years ago**.
- They entered South Asia roughly **65,000–45,000 BP**.
- Indian evidence for early humans is **fossils and stone tools**, not writing.
- **Hathnora** (Narmada Man) lies in the **Narmada valley of Madhya Pradesh**.
- The find is a ***Homo erectus* cranium**, not a *Homo sapiens* skull.
- **Arun Sonakia** of the GSI discovered it in **1982**.
- **Attirampakkam** lies in the **Kortallayar valley of Tamil Nadu**, near Chennai.
- It is a Lower Paleolithic **Acheulian tool** site dated to about **1.5 million years**.
- **Shanti Pappu's** team dated the tools.
- Attirampakkam is **not** a hominin fossil site.
- **Pallavaram** is in the Chennai belt of Tamil Nadu.
- **Robert Bruce Foote** recognised Paleolithic tools there in **1863**.
- He is called the **Father of Indian Prehistory**.
- Dates rest on **tool typology, stratigraphy, C-14, TL/OSL, and pollen**.
- There are **no** Stone Age written texts.
- *Homo erectus* left Africa about **1.8 million years ago**.
- Hathnora is still India's only widely cited early hominin skull.

- Pleistocene ice ages and warmer interglacials shaped migration routes.
- Camps cluster in **river valleys and rock shelters**.
- There is **no** universally agreed “first human site” in India.
- Siwalik ape fossils such as ***Sivapithecus*** are **not** proof of *Homo* in India.
- Siwalik ***Sivapithecus*** is an **ape** fossil. **Hathnora** is the *Homo erectus* skull.

> **Logic:** Hathnora is an ***erectus*** **fossil** found by **Sonakia in 1982**. Attirampakkam is **old tools** in the **Kortallayar valley, Tamil Nadu**. The trap is calling the Narmada find a modern human.

1.2 Stone Age

Three-Age System | C.J. Thomsen, 1836 (Denmark) | Stone → Bronze → Iron

- The **prehistoric** period has **no** written evidence.
- The **proto-historic** period has a script that is still **undeciphered**. It sits between prehistoric and historic. In the Indian frame, **Indus Valley** and many **Copper Age / Chalcolithic** cultures are treated as proto-historic.
- The **historic** period begins when we get usable written description. In North India that horizon is often placed around the **6th century BCE**.
- The **Stone Age** belongs to the **prehistoric** span.
- Systematic research on the Stone Age in India is often dated from **1863**, with **Robert Bruce Foote** at Pallavaram.
- Thomsen split museum collections into **Stone, Bronze, and Iron** (Copenhagen).
- The Stone Age is further split into **Paleolithic, Mesolithic, and Neolithic** by tool and economy.
- Dates in India are **regional**. There is no single national switch year.
- Northwest farming at **Mehrgarh** can begin around **7000 BCE** while Mesolithic hunting still continues in other belts.

Period	Approx. (India)	Economy	Defining fact
Paleolithic	~2 mya – 10,000 BCE	Hunting and gathering	Chipped stone (core, flake, blade)
Mesolithic	~10,000 – 4000 BCE	Hunting, fishing; some sedentism	**Microliths**
Neolithic	~7000 – 1000 BCE	Food production	Ground or polished stone, pottery, villages

- Older summaries often compress Mesolithic as **10,000–6000 BCE**. Many Indian microlithic camps run later, toward **4000 BCE**.
- The **Chalcolithic** is the Copper Age after the Stone Age. It is **not** a fourth Stone Age.
- Farming already exists in the Neolithic. Chalcolithic villages add **copper** beside stone.

Period	Approx. (India)	Economy	Defining fact
Chalcolithic	~3000 – 1000 BCE	Farming villages plus first metal	**Copper plus stone**; rural, not Harappan cities

- Each period has a typical **tool class**. That is how the three Stone Age stages are told apart.

Tool class	What it is	Typical period
Chopper / chopping	Pebble tool, one or both edges flaked	Lower Pal **Soanian**
Handaxe / cleaver	Bifacial core tool (Acheulian)	**Lower Paleolithic**
Flake	Struck from prepared core (Levallois)	**Middle Paleolithic**
Blade / burin / scraper	Long parallel-sided flake	**Upper Paleolithic**
Microlith	1–8 cm composite blade	**Mesolithic**
Celt / ground axe, quern	Polished/ground stone	**Neolithic**

- Cultures are dated by **tools, strata, C-14, and OSL**, not by kings.
- Common raw stone includes **quartzite, chert, agate, jasper, and flint**.
- The Stone Age **ends locally** when copper or bronze, and later urban Harappan cultures, appear.
- It does **not** end everywhere at once.

> **Logic:** Chalcolithic is **copper-stone**, not "Stone Age IV." Kashmir Neolithic is not the same date or crop as Tamil Nadu Neolithic. Jorwe fades around **1000 BCE**, so Chalcolithic does not stop at 1500 BCE.

1.3 Paleolithic Age

Old Stone Age | hunting-gathering bands | Pleistocene | no pottery or metal

- People lived in nomadic **bands**.
- There was **no** agriculture, pottery, or metal.
- Caves and rock shelters served as **seasonal camps**.
- Fire use becomes systematic later in the period.
- The Paleolithic falls in the **Pleistocene**.

Sub-period	Approx.	Tools (booklet triad)
Lower	~2 mya – 100,000 BP	**Handaxe, cleaver, chopper** — Acheulian / Soanian cores
Middle	~100,000 – 35,000 BP	**Points, borers, scrapers**; flake / Levallois

Sub-period	Approx.	Tools (booklet triad)
Upper	~35,000 – 10,000 BP	**Burins** with blades and scrapers; bone tools; ostrich-eggshell beads
Lower Pal tradition	Zone	Fact
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Soanian	Soan–Siwalik (Punjab/Pakistan)	Pebble **chopper-chopping**; Yale–Cambridge team under **H. De Terra** (with Paterson), **1935**
Acheulian (also called **Madrasian** in older books)	Peninsula + Narmada + Kortallayar	**Handaxe-cleaver**; Foote at **Pallavaram** and **Attirampakkam**

- The **Soanian** industry uses pebble **chopper-chopping** tools in the Soan–Siwalik belt.
- **De Terra and Paterson** described the Soanian sequence in the **1935** Yale–Cambridge expedition.
- The **Acheulian** (older books say **Madrasian**) industry uses **handaxes and cleavers**.
- Acheulian sites cluster in the peninsula, the Narmada, and the Kortallayar.
- Major tool valleys include the **Soan, Narmada, Godavari, Krishna, Kortallayar, Belan, and Son**.
- In the **Belan valley** (नवपाषाण), **G.R. Sharma** of Allahabad University led work that reported about **44** Lower Paleolithic sites.
- A bone **Mother Goddess** figurine from **Lohanda Nala** (Belan) is kept in the **Kaushambi** (कौशांबी) museum.
- Paleolithic people lived by **hunting and gathering**. They did **not** farm or keep herds.
- Controlled **fire** is older than farming in world prehistory. Some booklet stems still key “first fire use” to the **Neolithic** — treat that as a stem trap, not as absolute science.
- Holocene warming around **10,000 BCE** opens the Mesolithic.
- Occupation at **Bhimbetka** begins in the **Lower Paleolithic**.

> **Logic:** A **handaxe** is **Lower Paleolithic / Acheulian**. A **polished stone axe** is **Neolithic**. Soanian is not Acheulian.

1.4 Mesolithic Age

Middle Stone Age | Holocene warming ~10,000 BCE | microliths | hunting–fishing

- The Mesolithic begins with **Holocene** warming around **10,000 BCE**.
- In India it commonly runs toward **4000 BCE**. Some older summaries stop the period at **6000 BCE**.
- The economy is still hunting, gathering, and fishing.
- Camps become more sedentary near rivers and lakes.
- The **bow and arrow** was likely widespread, using microlith arrowheads.
- The defining tool is the **microlith**.
- A microlith is a tiny blade **hafted** in bone or wood as a **composite tool**.

- **Non-geometric** microliths (backed blades) are generally **earlier**.
- **Geometric** microliths (lunates, triangles, trapezes) are generally **later**.
- **A.C.L. Carlleyle** reported rock paintings from the **Vindhya** (विंध्य) region in **1867**. That find helped put Indian Mesolithic rock art on the map.
- **Bagor** lies in the Bhilwara belt of **Rajasthan** (थार), on the **Kothari** river.
- Bagor is the standard answer for Mesolithic **animal domestication**.
- It is often called India's **largest** Mesolithic site.
- **V.N. Misra** excavated Bagor.
- **Adamgarh** (Narmadapuram / Hoshangabad belt, Madhya Pradesh) also has early domestication evidence.
- Adamgarh is **not** the 2018 MCQ key (**Bagor** is).
- **Sarai Nahar Rai**, **Mahadaha**, and **Damdama** lie in **Pratapgarh, Uttar Pradesh**.
- They are Ganga-plain Mesolithic **cemeteries**.
- **Damdama** yielded about **41** human graves. About **5** are double burials. **One** triple burial is also reported.
- **Sarai Nahar Rai** has a grave with **four** (चातुर्याम) human skeletons.
- **Mahadaha** and **Sarai Nahar Rai** yield many **bone and horn** implements and ornaments. **J.N. Pandey**'s *Puratatva Vimarsh* discusses pointed bone objects from Sarai Nahar Rai, Damdama, and Mahadaha.
- **Lekhahia** (also Lekhahiya) in the Mirzapur Vindhyas has many skeletons from rock shelter 1. **J.N. Pandey** cites about **17**; **John R. Lukas** cites remnants of about **27**.
- A useful west-to-east Mesolithic line for geography stems is **Mahadaha** → **Lekhahia** → **Paisra** → **Birbhanpur**.
- Fishing, antler tools, and shell ornaments rise in riverine camps.
- The transition to the Neolithic is **gradual**.

> **Logic:** Mesolithic domestication fact = **Bagor** (and Adamgarh in older twin keys). **Odai, Bori, and Lakhnia** are distractors. **Bori** in Maharashtra is a claimed **Lower Paleolithic** site, not Mesolithic domestication. Triple burial = **Damdama**. Four-skeleton grave = **Sarai Nahar Rai**.
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> [!TIP] **Exam Anchor [UPPCS Prelims 2018, Q18]:** Early evidence of animal domestication in Mesolithic India at **Bagor** (Kothari River, Bhilwara, RJ) and **Adamgarh** (MP). *(See Q2 in Complete PYQ Bank below)*

1.5 Neolithic Age

New Stone Age | food production | pottery | ground stone | villages

- The Neolithic is defined by food **production**, **pottery**, **sedentism** (or semi-sedentism), and **ground or polished** stone tools.

- Typical tools are axes, querns, and pounders.

Region	Crop / trait
Northwest (Mehrgarh)	**Wheat, barley**
Eastern UP / Belan	**Rice** (Koldihwa, Mahagara)
Ganga plain (Lahuradewa)	Early **rice** (lake-edge; not Belan)
South India	**Millets**; **ash-mound** pastoral sites
Kashmir	Pit dwellings; fishing/hunting heavy (Burzahom, Gufkral)

- **Celts** (polished axes) were used for forest clearance.
- **Querns and mullers** were used to grind grain.
- Pottery is **handmade** first.
- The **wheel** appears in later Neolithic and Chalcolithic levels.
- There is no script and no coined money.
- Animals commonly domesticated by the full Neolithic include cattle, sheep, goat, buffalo, pig, and the **dog**.
- Settlements are **villages**, not cities.
- **Gordon Childe** coined **"Neolithic Revolution"** for this food-production shift.
- In West Asia, **barley** is often treated as the **first cultivated cereal** (around **8000 BCE**), with **wheat** close behind in the same Fertile Crescent belt.
- In the **Indian subcontinent**, early farming keys split by stem.
- **Lahuradewa** (Sant Kabir Nagar) carries early **rice** claims in some reports (~**9000–7000 BCE**).
- **Mehrgarh** carries early **wheat–barley** settled life (~**7000 BCE**).
- Belan **rice bran** near Prayagraj sits around **6500 BCE** in older Belan claims.
- If **Lahuradewa** is an option for "earliest agriculture in the subcontinent," booklet keys usually pick it. If it is absent, **Mehrgarh** is the usual key.
- **Mehrgarh** also shows cultural remains from the **Stone Age into the Harappan** horizon.
- South Indian **ash mounds** (burnt cattle-pen debris) occur at **Sanganakallu** (Ballari), **Piklihal**, and **Utnur**.

> **Logic:** A polished axe is **Neolithic**. The trap "all Neolithic sites grew rice" is false. Rice is **regional** (UP Belan and Lahuradewa). It is not Mehrgarh's first crop.

1.6 Chalcolithic Culture

First metal | copper plus stone | rural villages | not Harappan cities

- Chalcolithic people used **copper** together with **stone** tools.
- Settlements are **rural** farming villages.

- They have **no** Harappan-style street grid, covered drains, or citadel.
- Metal is mostly **copper**, not tin-bronze.
- **Copper** is the **first metal** widely used in India. The copper-plus-stone horizon is the **Chalcolithic** (Copper Age).
- Chalcolithic settlements concentrate in south-east **Rajasthan**, western **Madhya Pradesh**, western **Maharashtra**, and parts of south-east India.
- The **Ahar–Banas** culture lies in the **Udaipur / Mewar belt of Rajasthan** (about **2100–1500 BCE**).
- It is **contemporary with the Harappan** civilisation, not with Maurya or Gupta ages.
- It is known for **copper smelting**, metal work as a craft, **white-painted black-and-red ware**, and terracotta bulls.
- **Rice was known** to Ahar people. The stem “rice was unknown to them” is false.
- The **Kayatha** culture lies on the **Chambal in Madhya Pradesh**.
- It is known for sturdy **red-slipped** ware.
- The **Malwa** culture lies on the **Narmada in Madhya Pradesh**.
- **Navdatoli** (near Khargone / opposite Maheshwar) is the type site.
- It yielded channel-spouted cups.
- **H.D. Sankalia** excavated Navdatoli.
- Navdatoli houses include **round** huts about **3 m** across and **rectangular** rooms about **2 × 2.2 m**, with post-supported thatch, mud-plastered bamboo screens, lime-coated floors, and one- or two-mouthed **chulhas**.
- The **Savalda** culture lies on the **Tapi in Maharashtra**.
- It is the **pre-Jorwe** Deccan Chalcolithic.
- The **Jorwe** culture is the largest Deccan Chalcolithic.
- It uses painted **black-on-red** ware.
- **Inamgaon** is the type site. Other Jorwe sites include **Daimabad, Chandoli, and Nevasa**.
- People lived in large **rectangular** wattle-and-daub houses with thatched roofs.
- Adults were buried under the house floor in a **supine** position with the head to the **north** (north–south orientation).
- Children were often placed in **two urns** joined **mouth-to-mouth** and set horizontally in the pit.
- Jorwe fades around **1000 BCE**, after which iron spreads.
- **OCP** (Ochre Coloured Pottery) belongs to the Ganga–Yamuna **doab** of western UP, Haryana, and Rajasthan.
- It is porous, ochre-washed, and often worn at the edges.
- It is often linked to the **Copper Hoard** (harpoons, celts, anthropomorphs).
- **B.B. Lal** named / christened OCP during work at **Hastinapur** (1950–52). **Atranjikhera** is another classic OCP find-spot.

- **Ganeshwar–Jodhpura** in Rajasthan is a copper-working culture.
- It supplied metal toward the Harappan zone.
- Houses are mud or wattle-and-daub.
- **Balathal** shows an early **fortification-like** wall.
- OCP is **doab Chalcolithic**, not a Harappan city culture.
- Copper Hoard objects are also asked with IVC. The fact here is **doab plus copper artefacts**.

> **Logic: Inamgaon** is **Jorwe in Maharashtra**. **Navdatoli** is **Narmada / Malwa**, not Rajasthan. OCP is not Harappan urban ware. Ahar knew **rice** and was **Harappa-contemporary**.

1.21 Megalithic Culture (India)

Iron Age burial horizon | mainly Deccan and south | not Stone Age Chalcolithic

- Megaliths are **Iron Age** burial monuments of the **Deccan and south**. They are **not** Stone Age Chalcolithic village cultures.
- Common forms include **dolmens** (table stones), **cists** (stone-box graves), **stone circles**, and **menhirs** (upright pillars). Later **hero stones** (*virakkal*) commemorate warriors.
- Burials often carry **black-and-red ware**, iron weapons and tools, and gold ornaments. The culture marks the spread of **iron** in the peninsula after the north had moved through PGW.
- **Brahmagiri** in Karnataka is a classic megalithic site linked to early **Sangam** (संगम) archaeology.
- **Adichanallur** in Tamil Nadu is famous for urn burials and bronze artefacts.
- **Maski** (Karnataka) appears in **megalithic** lists and as Ashoka's **Minor Rock Edict** site — read the stem for which fact is asked.
- **Hallur** in Karnataka is another standard southern megalithic fact.
- In the **north**, Later Vedic **PGW** marks iron in the doab. Megaliths mark iron-age burial culture in the **peninsula**, not Harappan urbanism.
- **Burzahom** (Kashmir) has late **menhirs** in Period III. That is a northern exception, not the main megalithic belt.

1.22 Archaeological Dating and Evidence (Stone Age Toolkit)

- Indian prehistory is dated by **tool typology**, **stratigraphy** (स्तरिकी), **pollen analysis**, **C-14**, and **TL/OSL**.
- **Stratigraphy** means deeper layers are older; Paleolithic below Mesolithic shows continuity (e.g. Chopani Mando).
- **C-14** works on organic matter; very early Palaeolithic sites rely more on geology and typology.
- **Sivapithecus** Siwalik fossils are **not** evidence of *Homo* in India — trap against Hathnora.
- Terminal Pleistocene climatic drying is one reading for Vindhyan Stone Age groups moving toward the **Ganga valley**.
- The **Archaeological Survey of India** sits under the **Ministry of Culture**.

- In **1871** the Archaeological Survey became a separate department with **Alexander Cunningham** as first Director-General. He is often called the **Father of Indian Archaeology**.
- In **1901**, under **Lord Curzon**, it was centralized as the ASI. **John Marshall** took charge as DG in **1902**.
- **Robert Bruce Foote** was a British **geologist and archaeologist** (Geological Survey of India) and is called the **Father of Indian Prehistory**.
- South Indian excavators often named in IAS-style lists include **Alexander Rea**, **A.H. Longhurst**, **Robert Sewell**, **James Burgess**, and **Walter Elliot**.
- The **Indira Gandhi Rashtriya Manav Sangrahalaya** (National Museum of Mankind) is in **Bhopal**, Madhya Pradesh, under the Ministry of Culture.
- **Chandraketugarh** (West Bengal) is famous for **terracotta** art, not for Burzahom-style rock-cut shrines.
- **Mangadu** (Kollam, Kerala) is an excavated **megalithic** site.
- **Inamgaon** is correctly tagged as a Maharashtra **Chalcolithic** site in multi-row match stems.
- **Salihundam** (Andhra Pradesh) is a **Buddhist** monastic / stupa site, not rock-cut cave shrines of the Ajanta type.

1.7 Important Paleolithic Sites

Site ↔ state ↔ tool tradition | one name = one fact

- The **Soan (Sohan) Valley** in Punjab / Pakistan is the type area of Lower Paleolithic pebble **choppers** (Soanian), described by De Terra and Paterson.
- **Pallavaram** in Tamil Nadu yielded the first recognised Indian Paleolithic tools, identified by **R.B. Foote in 1863**.
- **Attirampakkam** in the Kortallayar valley of Tamil Nadu has Acheulian tools about **1.5 million years** old. It is not a fossil site.
- **Hathnora** on the Narmada in Madhya Pradesh yielded a ***Homo erectus* skull**, found by **Sonakia in 1982**.
- **Bhimbetka** in Raisen, Madhya Pradesh, has Lower Paleolithic tools in **rock shelters**, with paintings in later periods.
- **Adamgarh** near Hoshangabad, Madhya Pradesh, shows a Paleolithic-to-Mesolithic sequence on the Narmada.
- **Chopani Mando** in the Belan valley of Uttar Pradesh shows Paleolithic–Mesolithic–Neolithic **continuity**.
- **Nevasa** on the Pravara in Maharashtra has Paleolithic tools.
- **Didwana** on the Thar fringe in Rajasthan has Paleolithic tools.
- **Hunsgi** in Karnataka is an Acheulian factory site.
- **Isampur** in Karnataka is an Acheulian quarry.
- **Gudiyam cave** in Tamil Nadu is a Paleolithic rock-shelter / cave site.
- **Patne** in Maharashtra is Upper Paleolithic and is known for **ostrich eggshell** beads.
- The **Kurnool caves** in Andhra Pradesh yielded Upper Paleolithic **bone** tools, including Muchchatla Chintamanu Gavi.

- **Baghor** in the Son valley of Madhya Pradesh is an Upper Paleolithic stone **shrine**. It is **not** Bagor in Rajasthan.
- **Jwalapuram** in Andhra Pradesh has Middle Paleolithic tools around **Toba** volcanic ash.
- **Paisra** in Munger, Bihar, is an Acheulian workshop.
- **Kuliana** in Mayurbhanj, Odisha, has Paleolithic tools.
- **Anangpur** in the Delhi–Haryana belt is Acheulian.
- **Renigunta** in Andhra Pradesh has Upper Paleolithic blades.
- **Bori** in Maharashtra is a claimed early Paleolithic site. It was the **wrong option** in 2018 (domestication = Bagor).

> **Logic:** Attirampakkam is in **Tamil Nadu**, not Karnataka. **Baghor is not Bagor**. The Belan Valley is in **Uttar Pradesh** (उत्तर प्रदेश).

1.8 Important Mesolithic Sites

Microlith camps | domestication vs burial is the usual trap

- **Bagor** on the Kothari near Bhilwara, Rajasthan, is the Mesolithic **animal-domestication** key. It is often called the largest Mesolithic site. **V.N. Misra** excavated it.
- **Tilwara** on the Luni in Rajasthan is a Mesolithic camp.
- **Langhnaj** in Gujarat has microliths and human skeletons. **H.D. Sankalia** excavated it.
- **Loteshwar** in Gujarat sits on the Mesolithic–Neolithic transition.
- **Adamgarh** in Madhya Pradesh has early domestication and cereal-use claims. It is not the 2018 key.
- **Bhimbetka** in Raisen, Madhya Pradesh, has microliths in shelter floors.
- **Sarai Nahar Rai** in Pratapgarh, Uttar Pradesh, is a Mesolithic **cemetery** with antler tools and **wild-rice gathering**. **G.R. Sharma** excavated it. A grave with **four** skeletons is reported here.
- **Mahadaha** in Pratapgarh, Uttar Pradesh, is a large Mesolithic burial cluster with rich **bone and horn** implements.
- **Damdama** in Pratapgarh, Uttar Pradesh, is another Mesolithic burial site. About **41** graves include double burials and **one triple** burial.
- **Chopani Mando** in the Belan valley of Uttar Pradesh is advanced Mesolithic with wild rice, **before** Koldihwa farming.
- **Morhana Pahar** in **Sonbhadra** (सोनभद्र), Uttar Pradesh, has rock paintings.
- **Lekhahia** in Mirzapur, Uttar Pradesh, has rock art and a large skeleton count from rock shelter 1.
- **Birbhanpur** in West Bengal has microliths.
- **Teri sites** on the Tamil Nadu coast are coastal Mesolithic camps on red sand dunes.

> **Logic:** Bagor is **domestication**. Sarai Nahar Rai is **burials**. Morhana Pahar is in **Sonbhadra**, not Mirzapur.

1.9 Important Neolithic Sites

Crop and house type are regional | each site has its own fact

- **Mehrgarh** on the Kachi plain of **Balochistan (Pakistan)** is the earliest farming village in the subcontinent, around **7000 BCE**. First crops are wheat and barley. Houses are mud-brick. Period I is **aceramic**.
- **Burzahom** near Srinagar in Kashmir has **pit dwellings** about 2–4 m deep, bone tools, and **dog burial**.
- **Gufkral** in Pulwama, Kashmir, also has pit dwellings. The name means **"cave of the potter."**
- **Koldihwa** in the Belan valley of **Mirzapur, Uttar Pradesh**, has **rice-husk impressions** in pottery. **G.R. Sharma** excavated it.
- **Mahagara** in the same Belan valley has charred rice and a **cattle pen with hoof marks**.
- **Lahuradewa** in **Sant Kabir Nagar, Uttar Pradesh**, has early Ganga-plain **rice** at a lake edge. It is **not** a Belan site.
- **Chirand** in **Saran, Bihar**, is known for **bone and antler tools**. Stone tools are absent in the upper levels.
- **Senuwar** in Rohtas, Bihar, is Gangetic Neolithic.
- **Taradih** in Gaya, Bihar, is Gangetic Neolithic.
- **Hallur** in Karnataka is southern Neolithic and grew **millets**.
- **Piklihal** on the Karnataka–Andhra belt is **ash-mound** pastoral Neolithic, excavated by **F.R. Allchin**.
- **Utnur** in Andhra Pradesh is ash-mound cattle-pen Neolithic, also linked to Allchin.
- **Kodekal** in Karnataka is ash-mound Neolithic.
- **Paiyampalli** in Tamil Nadu is southern Neolithic.
- **Sanganakallu** (Sangana Kallu) in Ballari, Karnataka, is a Neolithic factory and settlement with famous **ash mounds**.
- **Maski** in Karnataka is a Neolithic settlement.
- **Brahmagiri** in Karnataka has a Neolithic–Megalithic sequence.
- **Tekkalakota** in Karnataka is southern Neolithic.
- **Kupgal** in Karnataka is an ash-mound cluster.
- **Daojali Hading** in Assam has cord-marked pottery and **shouldered celts**.
- **Sarutaru** in Assam is North-East Neolithic.
- **Napchik** in Manipur is North-East Neolithic.
- **Kuchai** in Odisha is Neolithic.
- **Golbai Sasan** in Odisha is Neolithic–Chalcolithic.

> **Logic:** Ash mounds are **South Indian**, not a Chirand feature. Lahuradewa is **Sant Kabir Nagar**, not Belan. Daojali Hading is in **Assam**, not Uttar Pradesh.

1.10 Important Chalcolithic Sites

Culture name + state is the match | rural copper-stone, not IVC cities

- **Ahar** near Udaipur, Rajasthan, is Ahar–Banas. It has copper smelting and white-painted **black-and-red ware**.
- **Balathal** in Rajasthan is Ahar culture with an early **fortification-like** wall.
- **Gilund** in Rajasthan is Ahar culture with a large platform.
- **Kayatha** on the Chambal in Madhya Pradesh is Kayatha culture with red-slipped ware.
- **Navdatoli** on the Narmada (opposite Maheshwar) in Madhya Pradesh is **Malwa** culture, excavated by **Sankalia**.
- **Eran** in Madhya Pradesh runs from Chalcolithic into early historic.
- **Gungeria** in Balaghat, Madhya Pradesh, yielded the **largest Copper Hoard**.
- **Inamgaon** on the Bhima in Maharashtra is the **Jorwe** type site, with mud houses and crops.
- **Daimabad** on the Pravara in Maharashtra is Jorwe / late Harappan and is known for a **bronze chariot**.
- **Jorwe** in Maharashtra is the name-giving site of painted black-on-red ware.
- **Nasik** (नासिक) in Maharashtra belongs to the same Jorwe painted-ware horizon.
- **Prakash** in Maharashtra belongs to the same Jorwe painted-ware horizon.
- **Bahal** in Maharashtra belongs to the same Jorwe painted-ware horizon.
- **Savalda** on the Tapi in Maharashtra is pre-Jorwe Deccan Chalcolithic.
- **Prabhas** in Gujarat has Prabhas ware.
- **Rangpur** in Gujarat has **lustrous red ware**.
- **Hastinapur** in the western UP doab is an **OCP** site. **B.B. Lal** excavated it.
- **Bahadarabad** in the doab is an OCP site.
- **Lal Qila** in the doab is an OCP site.
- **Bargaon** in the doab is an OCP site.
- **Ganeshwar** in Rajasthan is a copper-working site.
- **Jodhpura** in Rajasthan is a copper-working site paired with Ganeshwar.

> **Logic:** Inamgaon is in **Maharashtra**, not Rajasthan. Daimabad is **not** a pure mature Harappan city. Gungeria is a Copper Hoard site in **Madhya Pradesh**.

1.11 Cave Paintings

Rock-shelter walls | Vindhyan–Satpura belt | not Himalayan limestone caves

- Indian prehistoric art is mostly on **rock-shelter walls** in the Vindhyan–Satpura belt.
- It is **not** typically painted in deep Himalayan limestone caves.

Colour	Pigment	Typical use (Bhimbetka rule of thumb)
Red	Haematite / ochre	Animals
White	Limestone / kaolin	Human figures, dancers
Green	Chromium minerals	Less common
Black	Manganese / charcoal	Occasional

- Common themes are animals, hunting, **communal dancing**, riding, and geometric patterns.
- **Superimposition** means later paintings over older ones, so the art belongs to **multiple periods**.
- Mesolithic layers show hunting and dancing stick-figures.
- Historic layers show **horse riders**, processions, and battles.
- **Blue** is generally **absent**.
- Pigments were mixed with water or animal fat and applied by finger, twig, or hair brush.
- **Pachmarhi** in Madhya Pradesh is another painted belt.
- **Adamgarh** in Madhya Pradesh also has rock paintings.
- **Lakhudiyar** in Almora, **Uttarakhand** (उत्तराखंड), shows humans, animals, and geometrics in white, black, and red.
- **Morhana Pahar** in Sonbhadra, Uttar Pradesh, has rock paintings.
- **Lekhahia** in Mirzapur, Uttar Pradesh, has rock art.
- The premier painted cluster in India is **Bhimbetka** in Raisen, Madhya Pradesh.

> **Logic:** "All cave paintings are Paleolithic" is false. Lakhudiyar is in **Uttarakhand**, not at Bhimbetka. Red animals and white humans is a **Bhimbetka heuristic**, not a law for every site.

1.12 Rock Shelters

Natural overhangs | often Vindhyan sandstone | not quarried like Ajanta

- Rock shelters are **natural** overhangs formed by weathering, often in **Vindhyan sandstone**.
- Humans did **not** quarry them the way Ajanta or Ellora caves were cut.
- They were used as seasonal camps.
- Floors hold **habitation deposits**: stratified tools, bones, ash, and charcoal. Deeper layers are older.
- The main concentration is in the Vindhyan hills at Bhimbetka, which has **five clusters**.
- Belan and Sonbhadra shelters in Uttar Pradesh form a second concentration.
- **Auditorium Cave** at Bhimbetka is a large natural chamber, not a built hall.
- Some shelters later became Hindu or Buddhist shrines, so use is **multi-period**.

> **Logic:** Bhimbetka = **natural rock shelters** in the **Vindhyan** hills (Raisen, MP). Ajanta = later **carved** Buddhist caves.

1.13 Bhimbetka Rock Shelters

Raisen district, Madhya Pradesh | Abdullahganj–Raisen belt near Bhopal | ASI-protected

- **V.S. Wakankar** first recognised the prehistoric paintings in **1957–58**.
- He spotted the shelters from the Bhopal–Itarsi train and compared them with Spanish prehistoric shelters.
- Folk etymology links the name to **Bhima** of the Mahabharata “sitting” (*baithka*). It is not an excavated palace.
- UNESCO inscribed Bhimbetka as a World Heritage Site in **2003**.
- There are **750+** shelters, of which **500+** are painted, in **five** clusters.
- Painted themes include elephant, sambar, deer, and other animals.
- Tools begin in the **Lower Paleolithic**. Art runs from Mesolithic into **medieval** paintings. Use is often cited across about 100,000 years.
- **Zoo Rock** is famous for animal figures.
- **Auditorium Cave** is a large natural chamber.
- **Boar Rock** is another named painted shelter.
- **H.D. Sankalia** is not the discoverer. He is linked to Langhnaj and the Deccan.
- **V.N. Mishra** did later research at Bhimbetka. He was not the first visitor.
- **Madho Swaroop Vats** is a **Harappan** archaeologist and the 2020 distractor.

> **Logic:** Bhimbetka was excavated by **Wakankar** (1957–58). Vatsa is the Harappan trap.
>
> [!TIP] **Exam Anchor [UPPCS Prelims 2020, Q10]:** Discovery of **Bhimbetka Caves** rock paintings by Dr. **V.S. Wakankar** in **1957–1958** (UNESCO 2003). *(See Q1 in Complete PYQ Bank below)*

1.14 Microliths

Tiny flaked blades | typically 1–8 cm | hallmark of Mesolithic

- Microliths are tiny flaked blades, typically **1–8 cm**, made in **chert, agate, or jasper**.
- They are the **hallmark of the Mesolithic**, though they can linger into early Neolithic.
- They are too small to use alone, so they were **hafted** in bone or wood with resin as **composite tools**.
- Typical uses are arrowheads, sickle edges, and saws.
- They were struck from **fluted cores**.
- Many are **backed**, with one blunt edge for hafting.
- **Non-geometric** forms belong to earlier Mesolithic.
- **Geometric** forms (lunates, triangles, trapezes) belong to later Mesolithic.
- Dense clusters occur at Bagor, Langhnaj, Bhimbetka, and Sarai Nahar Rai.

> **Logic:** A microlith is not a Paleolithic handaxe. A microlith is not copper-plus-stone. Copper-plus-stone is Chalcolithic.

1.15 Neolithic Revolution

V. Gordon Childe | food collection to food production | staggered in South Asia

- The term was popularised by **V. Gordon Childe**.
- It names the shift from food **collection** to food **production** of plants and animals.
- Surplus, villages, and pottery follow that shift.
- The world had several **independent** centres, including West Asia, China, Mesoamerica, and South Asia.
- It is not only diffusion from one place.
- In the subcontinent the change is **staggered**.
- **Mehrgarh** around **7000 BCE** starts **aceramic**, then pottery appears.
- Gangetic rice at Belan and Lahuradewa is later and partly independent.
- South Indian millet and ash-mound cultures are later and partly independent.
- Surplus later supports craft, trade in stone and shell, and social ranking. Society is still **pre-urban**.
- This is not the Industrial Revolution.
- It is not a single pan-India year.

> **Logic:** Childe is not Wheeler or Marshall. Those two are Harappan excavators. “Revolution everywhere in India at once” is false.

1.16 Burzahom

Neolithic Kashmir Valley | Srinagar district | T.N. Khazanchi (ASI)

- **Burzahom** is a Neolithic site in the Kashmir Valley, in Srinagar district.
- The first excavation was by **Helmut De Terra** and **Thomas Paterson** in **1935**. Later ASI work is linked to **T.N. Khazanchi**.
- Nearby **Gufkral** in Pulwama means **“cave of the potter.”**
- Gufkral belongs to the same pit-dwelling culture.
- **Pit dwellings** were about **2–4 m** deep.
- Wooden posts and birch or thatch roofs covered the pits.
- Storage pits stood beside living pits.
- A later phase used **rectangular** houses **above** ground after the pits were abandoned.
- **Bone** harpoons, needles, and awls show lake fishing and craft.
- A **dog** was buried with a human skeleton. Antlered deer bones also occur in burial pits.

- Some human and animal bones show **trepanning** (bored holes).
- Some burials are crouched / sitting inhumations.
- A stone slab with an **engraved hunting** scene is a unique Kashmir fact.
- Red ware often shows **mat impressions**.
- Lentils and wheat appear later. Burzahom is **not** a rice-impression site.
- The period is roughly **3000–1000 BCE**, later than Mehrgarh.
- Period III has **megalithic menhirs**.

> **Logic:** Burzahom means **Kashmir pits** and **dog burial**. It is not in Uttar Pradesh and not a Chirand-style Ganga settlement. Gufkral is not a Paleolithic painted cave in the Bhimbetka sense.

1.17 Mehrgarh

Kachi plain, Balochistan (Pakistan) | earliest farming village | ~7000–2500 BCE

- Mehrgarh is the earliest known **agricultural village** in the **Indian subcontinent**.
- **Jean-François Jarrige** excavated it for the French mission.
- **Period I** is **aceramic** Neolithic: mud-brick houses and farming, but **no pottery**.
- Pottery appears in later periods.
- First crops are **wheat and barley**, not rice.
- **Cotton** seeds and fibres are also reported here. This is an early Old World cotton framing.
- Cattle, sheep, and goat were kept.
- Houses are mud-brick and multi-room, with storage bins.
- Terracotta **female figurines** occur.
- Long-distance materials include **lapis** and **turquoise** beads.
- Mehrgarh is a **pre-Harappan** precursor. Cultural remains run from the **Stone Age into the Harappan** horizon. It is **not** a mature Harappan city.
- Drilled teeth in early levels are an early dentistry claim. That is extra, not the core fact.

> **Logic:** The location is **Pakistan / Balochistan**, still “subcontinent” language. Traps: “Mehrgarh is in India,” “Mehrgarh is Harappa,” and “aceramic means no farming.” Aceramic means no **pottery**.

1.18 Chirand

Saran district, Bihar | Ganga near Chapra | bone-tool Neolithic

- Chirand is a Gangetic Neolithic site with later **Chalcolithic** layers, about **2500–1500 BCE** and after.
- **B.P. Singh** excavated it.
- **Bone and antler tools** dominate the upper levels.
- Typical objects are fish-hooks, harpoons, bangles, and arrowheads.

- Stone tools are **present below** and **absent in the upper** Neolithic layers.
- Pottery is handmade grey or red ware, often with **mica**.
- Fishing comes first. Later crops include rice, wheat, barley, lentil, and moong.
- There are **no** pit dwellings of the Burzahom type.
- There are **no** ash mounds of the South Indian type.

> **Logic:** Chirand is in **Bihar**, not Uttar Pradesh. A bone industry is not iron smelting. Wheat at Chirand does **not** make it Mehrgarh.

1.19 Koldihwa

Belan valley | Mirzapur district, Uttar Pradesh | G.R. Sharma

- **Koldihwa** is a Neolithic site in the Belan valley of Mirzapur.
- **G.R. Sharma** excavated it in the Allahabad University Belan project.
- **Rice-husk impressions** in crude handmade pottery are among the **earliest rice** claims in India.
- Dates are often cited around **6500 BCE**. Those dates are **debated**.
- Remember: **site, rice, and Uttar Pradesh** together.
- Ground axes and bone tools occur with handmade pottery.
- Pair it with **Mahagara** in the same valley.
- The Mesolithic forerunner is **Chopani Mando**, which has wild rice, not full farming.
- **Lahuradewa** in Sant Kabir Nagar is a **separate** eastern-UP rice site at a lake edge.
- **Lahuradewa** is in **Sant Kabir Nagar**. The Belan pair is **Koldihwa–Mahagara** near Prayagraj.

> **Logic:** Koldihwa is **Belan UP plus rice**. Mehrgarh did **not** start as a rice centre. Lahuradewa is not Koldihwa.

1.20 Mahagara

Sister site of Koldihwa | same Belan valley, Uttar Pradesh | G.R. Sharma horizon

- **Mahagara** is the sister Neolithic site of Koldihwa in the Belan valley.
- **Charred rice grains** give direct crop evidence, beside Koldihwa's pottery impressions.
- **Circular hut** post-holes mark the houses.
- A **cattle pen / enclosure** with **hoof impressions** is the distinctive Mahagara fact.
- That find shows herding, not just hunting.
- Bones of cattle and deer show mixed hunting plus farming.
- Do **not** relocate Mahagara to Bihar or Kashmir.

> **Logic:** Mahagara and Koldihwa are **one UP rice pair**. The cattle pen is **Mahagara**, not Burzahom pits. Chopani Mando is the **Mesolithic** neighbour, not a Harappan port.
